



HIGHER HEALTH

POLICY ON PROGRAMME DEVELOPMENT



Policy on Programme Development

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Glossary

“Access” means entry to an occupational qualification, part-qualification or skills programme, or entry to a final external summative assessment

“Accreditation” means the certification, usually for a particular period, of a person, a body or an institution as having the capacity to fulfil a particular function in the quality assurance system set up by the Quality Council for Trades and Occupations (QCTO)

“Applied competence” means the ability to put into practice in the relevant context, the learning outcomes acquired in the process of obtaining a qualification or part-qualification (or skills programme). Applied competence encapsulates foundational, reflexive and practical competence.

“Certification” means formal recognition of a qualification or part-qualification (accredited skills programme) awarded to a successful learner

“Credits” means the amount of learning contained in a qualification or part-qualification whereby one credit is equal to ten (10) notional learning hours.

“Credit accumulation” means the totalling of credits towards the completion of a qualification or a part-qualification

“Curriculum” means a statement of the training structure and expected methods of learning and teaching that underpin a qualification or part-qualification (skills programme) to facilitate a more general understanding of its implementation in an education system

“e-learning” means a mode of teaching and learning that makes use of technology-mediated features.

“entry-level requirements” means the minimum academic knowledge and/ or practical competencies, and/or work experience that a learner must have completed in order to be admitted for study towards a qualification or part-qualification; this may include recognition of other forms of prior learning such as non-formal and informal learning and work experience deemed as comparable for entry

“Evaluation of learning” means a process involving gathering evidence and making informed judgements about a learning programme, or module or component of a learning programme; or its curriculum, learning materials or assessment; or its impact on learners or society. Evaluation involves making a judgement about the worth, merit or impact of learning or a programme of learning.

“Exit level outcomes” means the knowledge, skills and attitudes that a learner should have obtained or mastered on completion of a qualification and against which the learner is assessed for competence.

“Feedback” means specific reporting from the teacher to the learner or between learners, on how they have performed in an assessment activity, regardless of the level of formality of the assessment activity. Feedback specifies what was done well, and why, and provides clear guidance regarding what

is missing or still needs development in learners' texts, performances or demonstrations, in order to enhance learning.

"Formal learning" means learning that occurs in an organised and structured education and training environment and that is explicitly designated as such. Formal learning leads to the awarding of a qualification or part-qualification registered on the NQF.

"Informal learning" means learning that results from daily activities related to paid or unpaid work, family or community life, or leisure, including incidental learning.

"Learner" is an inclusive term referring to anyone learning, including pupils, students, apprentices, interns, learners in learnerships, people doing training, and people learning non-formally and informally as well as people enrolled for particular qualifications or part-qualifications, and people learning in contact, distance, and self-study contexts at all levels in the system.

"Learning" means the acquisition of knowledge, understanding, values, skills, competence and/or experience

"Learning outcomes" mean the contextually demonstrated end-products of specific learning processes, which include knowledge, skills and values.

"Learning pathway" means sequencing of qualifications that allows learners to move vertically, diagonally, and in some cases horizontally, through NQF levels giving learners recognition for full or partially completed qualifications or part-qualifications. Learning pathways can also lead to professional designations, when learning pathways include periods of structured work experience over and above qualifications.

"Level" means one of the series of levels of learning achievement arranged in ascending order from one to 10 according to which the NQF is organised and to which qualification types are linked

"Level descriptor" means a statement describing learning achievement at a particular level of the NQF that provides a broad indication of the types of learning outcomes and assessment criteria that are appropriate to a qualification at that level

"National Qualifications Framework (NQF)" is a comprehensive system approved by the Minister of Higher Education and Training for the classification, registration, publication and articulation of quality assured national qualifications.

"Non-formal learning" means planned educational interventions that are not intended to lead to the awarding of qualifications or part-qualifications.

"Notional hours of learning" comprise the total amount of time it would take the average learner to meet the outcomes defined in a learning experience and include *inter alia*, face to face contact time, time spent in structured learning in the workplace, time for completing assignments and research, and time spent in assessment processes.

“NQF Act” means the South African National Qualifications Framework (NQF) Act No. 67 of 2008.

“Occupational qualification” means a qualification associated with a trade, occupation or profession, resulting in learning in and for the workplace.

“Outcomes” means the contextually demonstrated end-products of specific learning processes which include knowledge, skills and values. Outcomes could be generic in that they could apply across many fields of learning (generic outcomes include aspects such as “ability to problem solve” or “understanding the world as a set of inter-related systems”).

“Part-qualification” means an assessed unit of learning that is registered as part of a qualification. This also refers to a unit standard, module, skills programme on the QQSF.

“Practical competence” means the demonstrated ability to perform a set of tasks and actions in authentic contexts

“Progression” is the means by which individuals are permitted to move through NQF levels by accumulating appropriate combinations of credit.

“Quality” means meeting the requirements of nationally agreed outcomes and performance/assessment criteria, thus facilitating both provision and monitoring.

“Quality Assurance” means the processes of ensuring that specified standards or requirements for teaching, learning, education administration, assessment and the recording of achievements have been met. The QQSF further defines it as systems and procedures to ensure that occupational qualifications meet industry standards and requirements

“Skills Programme” means a QCTO-accredited learning programme that is occupationally based and which, when completed, may constitute credits towards a qualification registered on the NQF.

1. Background

Higher Health is a non-profit organisation focused on the health and wellness of the youth in the post-school education and training (PSET) sector. Higher Health's model of delivering health and wellness services is to empower PSET learners to take charge of their health and wellness, through education and knowledge. Higher Health's programmes are intense, and were delivered in-person. It soon became apparent that more learners could be reached if the programmes were offered online, via e-learning. Learners also wanted recognition for attending the sessions. Higher Health therefore developed its e-learning Civic and Soft Skills Programme, which the QCTO accredited as a NQF Level 5 Skills Programme. As Higher Health worked with the content for this Skills Programme, it became apparent that all the modules were inter-connected, and that good citizenship underpinned all of the learning. Hence, the module on civic education was included as the first module, and the inter-connected nature of the modules was highlighted in the curriculum design.

2. Purpose

- a. The purpose of this policy is to describe Higher Health's approach to curriculum development of its skills programmes.
- b. This policy aims to contribute to the assurance and enhancement of the quality of curricula at Higher Health by providing a set of principles on which curricula was based.

3. Legislative and Regulatory Framework

This policy must be read in conjunction with

- I. QCTO OQSF Policy (2021);
- II. General Principles and Minimum Requirements on E-Assessment of Qualifications and Part Qualifications on the Occupational Qualifications Sub-Framework (OQSF); and
- III. Level Descriptors for the South African NQF (SAQA, 2012).

4. Scope and Application

This policy applies to Higher Health's skills programmes that are accredited as such by the Quality Council on Trades and Occupations (QCTO).

5. Principles

Higher Health's Civic and Soft Skills Programme was developed with the following principles in mind:

- a. The curriculum design is guided by principles related to learning outcomes, as described in the “Level Descriptors for the South African NQF” (SAQA, 2012), that describe what learners should know and be able to do (applied competence) once they have completed the curriculum. These outcomes are pegged at a particular level of learning and measured using credit values, which provide an indication of the amount of learning time (notional hours) required to achieve them. The use of learning outcomes, NQF levels and credits as a principle in curriculum design is therefore key to the functioning of the NQF.
- b. The curriculum should prepare learners for participation in both the formal and informal economies.
- c. The curriculum should impact local communities through its pedagogy of “each one teach ten”.
- d. The curriculum is designed as a co-curriculum, to be completed in tandem with formal qualifications at universities, TVET and CET Colleges.
- e. While articulation to other part qualifications and qualifications is not immediately apparent, it is the end-goal of Higher Health to allow for progression towards a Higher Certificate on the OQSF.
- f. The curriculum is designed to contribute to the full personal development of each learner, and the social and economic development of society at large, by incorporating the ten (and other) soft skills demanded by employers, and needed by entrepreneurs, into the curriculum.
- g. The Civic and Soft Skills curriculum seeks to improve livelihoods, promote inclusion into the world of work and support community and individual needs, through its design.
- h. While there is no restriction on who is eligible to enrol for the skills programme, Higher Health recommends that the learner should have minimum competencies at NQF Level 1 (post ABET 4; NQF Level 1 occupational certificate; or at least a Grade 9 school-leaving qualification).
- i. South Africa has 12 official languages, and a myriad of other dialects. In order to optimise teaching and learning, Higher Health will endeavour to offer the Civic and Soft Skills Programme in all 12 official languages over time, beginning with English; Afrikaans; isiZulu; Sesotho; and Sign Language.
- j. Considering that Higher Health’s Civic and Soft Skills Programme is a co-curriculum, learners must be free to work through the content at their convenience and at their own pace. The curriculum is therefore offered on an e-learning platform, and can be accessed through any smart device.
- k. Learners may begin with any of the modules, as long as they complete a module before moving on to the next module.

- l. The activities within the modules are designed to build and practise soft skills. Peer engagement is encouraged for all activities, as this promotes peer learning.
- m. The final assessments, leading to certification at NQF Level 5, is also done through the e-learning platform, at designated dates and times.
- n. The curriculum is designed with the youth in mind, so that activities used within the modules are youth-friendly.
- o. Simple English is used as a rule, for ease of understanding and translation into other languages.
- p. The learning outcomes of the curriculum are aligned to the exit level outcomes pegged at NQF Level 5.
- q. The curriculum is piloted to check its suitability for the target audience.
- r. The curriculum content is checked and updated regularly to keep up with the latest technologies, trends and information available.
- s. Learner feedback is elicited regularly to inform curriculum review decisions.
- t. Key stakeholders are consulted during curriculum amendments, to ensure that all relevant voices are heard and accommodated.

6. Roles and Responsibilities

- a. Higher Health has a curriculum content team that designs the curriculum, based on a set of criteria.
- b. Once the curriculum is developed, it is submitted to the QCTO for approval.
- c. Once approved, the curriculum implementation team incorporates the curriculum into the e-learning platform.
- d. Once learners are registered on the platform, the curriculum implementation team has regular feedback sessions with them, and makes recommendations to the curriculum content team, if changes are required.
- e. It is Higher Health's aim in future, to build on the current curriculum for progression to a Higher Certificate on the Occupational Qualifications Sub-Framework (OQSF), and articulation within and across sub-frameworks, thus giving learners flexibility in their learning pathways.

7. Review

- a. Higher Health will review the curriculum content every three years to ensure that it is still fit for purpose.

- b. New modules will be developed and added; or new skills programmes will be registered, to allow for progression and articulation, as described in 6e above.